Such was the speed with which India's revolutionary movements mushroomed that different organizations rose up across India. In the words of Kama Maclean, 'By the late 1920s, the small but powerful canon of martial heroes and nationalist models had been established, which provided a framework within which dissidents could aspire to challenge the Raj.'[5] The most notable of these were in Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Bengal. The febrile atmosphere of the time is evocatively described by Moffat. He explains how 'across North India in the 1920s appeared a constellation of temporary safe houses, mobile bomb factories and shifting weapon holds, perpetually under threat of detection'.[6] Elsewhere he writes how 'the 1920s are filled with incitement to rupture'.[7]

Bhagat Singh has come to epitomize that remembrance. This was not because he was hanged in Lahore Jail (now in Pakistan) on 23 March 1931, together with Rajguru and Sukhdev, when the schedule for his hanging was moved forward by eleven hours, much to everyone's shock. It is because his execution was not the first for the crime of conspiracy against the King, because '[t]hroughout the early 1920s, the government of India prosecuted a number of inter-provincial conspiracy cases against a range of insurgent groups who used political violence; many of these cases involved revolutionary terrorists from Bengal, who had made links with their counterparts in other provinces.' We forget today how truly young some of these people were. Many were barely out of their teens. There was the nineteen-year-old Khudiram Bose, who was hanged 112 years ago by the British government for his attack on the British magistrate Charles Kingsford, in which two British ladies were accidentally killed. His defence counsel argued that his compatriot Prafulla Chaki threw the bomb. Prafulla, who was older and much stronger, had immediately committed suicide. Khudiram was still sentenced to death. According to the Amrita Bazar Patrika, 'he walked to the gallows firmly and cheerfully and even smiled when the cap was drawn over his head'. Pitambar Das wrote a song '*Ekbar biday de Ma ghure ashi*', which describes Khudiram saying goodbye to his mother before going to the gallows, a song almost every Bengali child has grown up listening. He was hanged in Muzaffarpur in Bihar. A jail still